

MASK SLIP

Feature Bible & World Guide

Mythology, Characters, and Franchise Packaging

By Zoe Miller

1. LOGLINE & PREMISE

When her estranged younger sister vanishes into an upstate wellness retreat, a sound healer who spent four years surviving a narcissist of her own goes undercover inside the compound — and has to decide whether the charismatic founder's hold over dozens of followers is a supernatural hunger passed down four generations, or simply the most ordinary evil this country produces, dressed in incense and good lighting, before her sister becomes its next “Primary Supply.”

MASK SLIP is a stand-alone feature built on top of a larger, deliberately unresolved mythology: is “The Hollow” a dark-entity attachment that has moved from host to host for at least four generations, or is it simply what an unusually dense concentration of Dark Triad/Tetrad traits looks like once it finds a room willing to worship it? The screenplay never answers this. This document treats both readings as equally canonical, because the ambiguity is the point.

2. THEMATIC THESIS

The film's horror mechanics are a literalization of real narcissistic-abuse dynamics, dramatized rather than explained:

- **DARVO** (Deny, Attack, Reverse Victim and Offender) — Rafe's default move under any accusation, dramatized at the Founders' Dinner rather than named aloud on the page; it surfaces as a label only once, on an index card in Wren's own studio in the final scene.
- **Flying monkeys** — the four-member “soft perimeter” that turns Patrice around in Act Two without ever touching her; weaponized concern as containment.
- **Love-bombing & isolation** — Ivy's arc, and the mechanism Grandma Wren already survived once with Derek.
- **Grandiose, covert, and communal narcissism** — embodied respectively by Rafe (grandiose), Selah (covert), and the Circle's entire “radical authenticity” architecture itself (communal — a pedestal the whole congregation builds and defends together).
- **Dark Triad / Tetrad** — the in-world rational counter-theory, sourced to a fictional 1968 academic paper by “Dr. Okafor,” who studied the Aurelias' grandfather's compound and concluded “no ghosts required.”

The healing thesis, per Nan Cassidy's rule of thumb: fear, shame, and an audience feed the pattern, whatever “the pattern” ultimately is. Refusing all three is the only thing that has ever visibly dented it — dramatized at the climax, never stated as a moral.

3. WORLD & MYTHOLOGY

The Aurelia Circle — a present-day wellness retreat in the fictional town of Hollow Creek, publicly branded “Radical Authenticity / Communal Awakening.”

Lineage — founded as “The Vesper Society” by E. Aurelio in the 1950s; an archive photograph traces the same eyes and the same stillness back to a formal portrait dated 1911. Jonah's working theory: “every generation, one

of them ‘hosts’ it... it never runs out of hungry rooms to move into.”

Mask hierarchy — wood, bone, silver, gold, in ascending rank/“integration” level. The gold mask is worn only by Rafe.

Key rituals — “Radical Honesty” circle (public, gentle, communal humiliation dressed as intimacy); the “Unveiling” (a chapel mask-removal ceremony in concentric rings by rank; newer members still fight it, senior members are “dead-eyed” and compliant); daily “gratitude circles.”

The Ledger — members are tracked by rank; the vocabulary is “Supply,” “Primary,” and “Transferred” — never “died,” never “left.” Rosalind Cassidy (1994): SUPPLY – PRIMARY, TRANSFERRED. Ivy Mercer, present day: NEXT PRIMARY SUPPLY (PENDING).

The franchise network — at least nine “sister circles” nationally (the Meridian Circle is seen directly), each independently run but financially bound to the Aurelia name's start-up capital — the abuse pattern replicating through an institution, not just through one man.

The clock — the Autumn Unveiling, ten days out from Wren's arrival, when all nine circles send delegates to name the year's new Primary in front of witnesses. Once announced there, per Jonah, it stops being a private tragedy and becomes a consecration with a guest list — the concrete deadline the plot runs against.

The Hollow — the ambiguous entity/voice at the center of the Unveiling. Genuinely eerie, and simultaneously explained, on the page, by hidden subwoofers, staged infrasound, and drugged tea found in the chapel's service passage. Both explanations are fully supported by the text. Neither is confirmed, including in the film's final scene.

4. CHARACTER BIBLE

Protagonist

WREN MERCER

Early 30s. Sound healer and informal cult-literacy expert, taught everything she knows by surviving four years with a covert narcissist (“Derek”). Her Lightworker arc: she does not defeat the antagonist with force, she stops feeding it fear, shame, and an audience. The film’s moral and structural center.

IVY MERCER

Wren’s younger sister. Drawn in by being “picked first” for the first time in her life; being quietly groomed as the next Primary Supply. Her arc runs from performed loyalty to a single, hard-won honest sentence at the climax.

Antagonists

RAFE AURELIO

40s. Founder of the Aurelia Circle. Grandiose-narcissist charisma at the edge of the uncanny; the film keeps genuinely open whether he is a man, a four-generation pattern taught like a family trade, or a host body for something older. Master of DARVO.

SELAH AURELIO

40s. Co-founder and “Keeper of the Circle.” Covert-narcissist enabler with real self-awareness — the character most likely to tell Wren something true in the same breath as something manipulative. Fifteen years into a marriage that is “the machine that replaced one.”

MARCUS

50s. Senior “Keeper” and the estate’s surveillance/enforcement arm. Never raises his voice. The clearest embodiment of the Dark Triad reading — calculated, unbothered, entirely without the ambiguity afforded to Rafe and Selah.

Allies

JONAH PRICE

30s. Groundskeeper, skeptic, Lucia’s brother. Stayed for a rescue mission and discovered the hostage doesn’t want rescuing — a co-dependency arc that mirrors Wren’s own. First to clock Rafe’s DARVO reflex out loud, without ever naming the acronym.

PIPER LUND

Late 20s. Came in at nineteen; demoted, punished, and quietly redeemed across the film by helping Wren at real personal cost. Ends the film unresolved — the story refuses to promise she “stays saved.”

NAN CASSIDY

70s. Wren’s mentor; lost her daughter Rosalind to the organization’s earlier form in 1994. Gives Wren a cracked mirror pendant — not a weapon, a refusal to be gaslit. Has made peace with thirty years of not knowing what she’s actually facing.

DORIS

60s widow, ten genuine years in the Circle. Embodies the film’s hardest question: real healing and complicity can occupy the same person without contradiction. Helps Wren anyway, without renouncing her own decade.

GRACE ODOM

Early 40s. Left the Circle four years ago; runs the local feed store. The most honest voice in the film on the entity-vs-psychology question: she has stopped trying to decide which one is true.

Cult Ecosystem & Institutions

LUCIA & THEO

True believers, genuinely happy. Lucia's well-intentioned betrayal of Ivy at the midpoint is the film's clearest statement that conditioning, not malice, does most of the damage inside the Circle.

MARGUERITE

50s, six years in. The “dead-eyed” endpoint of full integration — a living preview of what Ivy is being groomed to become.

SHERIFF REYES & COUNCILWOMAN DIAZ

Reyes: institutional caution that cracks, slightly, when given real evidence — the film's one working (if narrow) civic remedy. Diaz: town-level complicity; her closing beat is the film's franchise stinger (see Section 5).

THE MERIDIAN LEADER

Runs a “sister circle” two states over. Confirms, in one scene, that the Aurelia Circle is a franchise, not an isolated case — the scale of the threat is organizational, not personal.

5. FRANCHISE & ANTHOLOGY POTENTIAL

MASK SLIP is written and delivered as a complete, self-contained feature. It is also built, deliberately, to support packaging beyond a single title:

- The Circle is explicitly one of at least nine “sister circles” already operating nationally — established on the page, not invented after the fact.
- The final scene shows the pattern surviving this film's ending: Councilwoman Diaz, alone and unwatched, goes briefly “present but absent” — the same language used for the Circle's most integrated members — while approving a new “Community Partnership” folder under a different name and logo (“a sun without a mask”).
- This supports an anthology model rather than a direct sequel: each future installment could follow a new protagonist inside a different sister circle, connected by the mask/ledger/Hollow mythology rather than by shared lead characters — each entry independently pitchable, financeable, and castable, while preserving brand and IP continuity across a slate.

6. TONE & VISUAL REFERENCE

Comps: Pan's Labyrinth (dark-fairytale ambiguity, ritual imagery that never confirms its own reality), Hereditary (ambiguity as structure, not cop-out), The Invitation (slow-burn infiltration dread), Martha Marcy May Marlene (grounded, unsentimental cult psychology), Midsommar (communal, sunlit dread), Sound of My Voice (restraint around the central unanswered question).

Visually: the Circle should look genuinely, seductively beautiful — golden hour, string lights, warm linen — so that its curdling reads as betrayal, not as a set the audience distrusted from frame one. Masks are the film's central recurring visual motif, escalating in material (wood to bone to silver to gold) the way rank escalates in dialogue. The Unveiling rite (ash marks, a passed ceremonial cup, chant sliding from English into an older invented tongue) is the film's Pan's-Labyrinth-register set piece — overtly mythic imagery, including a brief generational vision at the climax, staged so it reads as ritual, drug, or something older without the film ever picking one. “The Hollow” should be built practically wherever possible, kept ambiguous by staging and sound design rather than by visual effects, preserving the film's central refusal to resolve real vs. staged.

7. MUSIC & IP PACKAGING

MASK SLIP is adapted from Zoe Miller's original song “The Mask,” which she owns outright — a genuine packaging asset for a trailer, teaser, or music one-pager, distinct from the script itself:

“When you see it / you cannot un-see it / the mask slip / the horror of the reveal / of what lies beneath / the dark entity / witnessed, dead-eyed darkness in the eyes...”

Per standard spec convention, the song is not multiplied across in-scene cues in the shooting draft itself — it belongs here, in pitch and packaging materials, as a signature theme and title-page credit.

8. FORMAT & CONTACT

Feature | 94 pages | Draft 2 (Full-Length Revision) | Genre: Elevated Thriller / Horror

Zoe Miller — Screenwriter & Songwriter